

**ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026**

# Biotechnology English

## Conversation lab

Use these role cards to practice a response, handle a follow-up, and repeat with a new communication challenge.

### **PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK**

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For biotech scientists, translational researchers, assay-development teams, platform teams, program managers, alliance managers, business-development staff, and biotech executives.

Fictional language practice for professional communication. Clinical, safety, regulatory, and patient-care decisions follow qualified supervision and current local procedures.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

# How to use the conversation lab

1. Read the shared case. Spend two minutes noting the facts and your first response.
2. Assign roles. The responding professional uses role A; the listener uses role B. Read your own role privately before you begin.
3. Speak for 45-60 seconds. The listener asks a follow-up instead of simply agreeing. Continue until the meaning and next action are clear.
4. Reveal the model response. Identify one useful expression and compare it with your own wording.
5. Switch roles. Use the second-round challenge and speak again with fewer notes.

## If you are studying alone

Speak both roles aloud. Leave a pause after the question, then answer without looking at the model. You can also write a four-turn exchange and read it back for clarity.

## Useful conversation repair

- Could you say that another way?
- When you say that, which part do you mean?
- Let me check that I understood correctly.
- I need a moment to separate what is confirmed from what is still unknown.

## Feedback

Judge whether the listener understands the situation and can identify the next action or unresolved question. Correct one meaning issue and one useful language pattern, then repeat.

## CONVERSATION 01

# Platform Technology and Scientific Thesis

**SHARED CASE**

A platform produces a promising signal in one experimental system. An investor slide says it will work across several diseases.

**Role A | Responding professional**

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

**Role B | Listener**

You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

**Useful expressions**

The available evidence shows ... .

This may indicate ..., but ... .

We have not yet established whether ... .

**Cover this until after your first attempt**

The finding is promising in this experimental system. We have not established its relevance across diseases. I'll distinguish the current evidence from the broader platform hypothesis.

**Second round**

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

**Debrief**

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

## CONVERSATION 02

# Assay Development and Reproducibility

**SHARED CASE**

An assay gives consistent results within one run but different results across three days. A colleague calls it fully reproducible.

**Role A | Responding professional**

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

**Role B | Listener**

You favor one option but have not checked whether the scope is comparable. Ask about one difference, then explain the tradeoff you are willing to accept.

**Useful expressions**

Both options ..., but ... .

Option A ..., whereas option B ... .

The comparison depends on ... .

**Cover this until after your first attempt**

Within-run consistency and performance across days are different questions. Let's report both and investigate the between-day variation before describing the assay as reproducible under those conditions.

**Second round**

Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

**Debrief**

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

## CONVERSATION 03

# Biomarkers and Translational Strategy

**SHARED CASE**

A team calls a biomarker "validated" without specifying whether it means analytical performance or clinical usefulness.

**Role A | Responding professional**

Clarify missing information before responding. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

**Role B | Listener**

You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

**Useful expressions**

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is ... . Is that right?

**Cover this until after your first attempt**

What kind of validation do you mean here? Could we distinguish the assay's analytical performance from evidence about the biomarker's clinical use? The slide needs to state which claim the data support.

**Second round**

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

**Debrief**

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

## CONVERSATION 04

# Preclinical Data Packages

**SHARED CASE**

An animal study shows an effect at one tested exposure. A summary describes the result as proof of human benefit.

**Role A | Responding professional**

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

**Role B | Listener**

You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

**Useful expressions**

The available evidence shows ... .

This may indicate ..., but ... .

We have not yet established whether ... .

**Cover this until after your first attempt**

The result describes the tested animal model and exposure. It does not establish human benefit. I'll state the finding and the limits on translating it to a clinical setting.

**Second round**

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

**Debrief**

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

## CONVERSATION 05

# CMC and Scale-Up in Biotech

**SHARED CASE**

A process transfer achieved the expected yield in two small runs. Performance at a larger scale remains untested.

**Role A | Responding professional**

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

**Role B | Listener**

You need to brief someone who has only one minute. Ask what is complete, what is open, and which open item affects the next action.

**Useful expressions**

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is ... .

The next update will cover ... .

**Cover this until after your first attempt**

The two small runs met the expected yield. Larger-scale performance is still untested. I'll present scale-up as an open question and identify the next planned evidence point.

**Second round**

The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

**Debrief**

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

## CONVERSATION 06

# IP, Freedom to Operate, and Collaboration

**SHARED CASE**

Two partners want to exchange materials. The draft arrangement leaves publication and permitted-use questions unresolved.

**Role A | Responding professional**

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

**Role B | Listener**

You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

**Useful expressions**

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know ...

**Cover this until after your first attempt**

Could the responsible teams confirm the permitted uses and publication terms before the exchange? I'll summarize the scientific purpose and the unresolved questions for review.

**Second round**

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

**Debrief**

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

## CONVERSATION 07

# Investor and Board Updates

**SHARED CASE**

A project update lists completed experiments but does not connect them to the next funding milestone.

**Role A | Responding professional**

Explain a useful distinction in plain English. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

**Role B | Listener**

You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

**Useful expressions**

In this context, ... means ... .

The difference is that ... .

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

**Cover this until after your first attempt**

I'll group the results around the milestone question: what have we learned, what remains uncertain, and what evidence is needed next? That will make the funding discussion easier to follow.

**Second round**

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

**Debrief**

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

## CONVERSATION 08

# Partnering and Business Development

**SHARED CASE**

A potential partner requests exclusive rights before the scope of the collaboration is defined.

**Role A | Responding professional**

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

**Role B | Listener**

You want the preferred outcome but can accept one tradeoff. Ask for two options, then state which condition you can accept and which still needs approval.

**Useful expressions**

We can ..., provided that ... .

Would you prefer ... or ...?

I can take that proposal for review; I cannot yet confirm ... .

**Cover this until after your first attempt**

We can discuss exclusivity alongside the proposed scope, responsibilities, and milestones. Could we first clarify which activities and rights you have in mind so the appropriate teams can evaluate the request?

**Second round**

The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

**Debrief**

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

# Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

## Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

## Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

## Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

## Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

## Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

## Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

## Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

# Use the language responsibly

Fictional language practice for professional communication. Clinical, safety, regulatory, and patient-care decisions follow qualified supervision and current local procedures.

## Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

## Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

### Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

### Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

## Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.